

KF Mini-Meeting Lesson 4

--"MINI-MEETING" FORMAT-- (20 min)

I - MINDFULNESS (4 min)

-ANB (1 min)

-3 Minute Breathing Space (3 min)

II - CHECK-IN (10 min)

-KF Member "A" shares (5 min)

(1) What I learned

(2) Signs of MO

(3) Signs of Orientation

(4) Five things I am thankful for

-KF Member "B" shares (5 min)

(1) What I learned

(2) Signs of MO

(3) Signs of Orientation

(4) Five things I am thankful for

III - KF MEETING "PREVIEW" (6 min)

-Bible Teaching -- selected excerpt of upcoming KF Bible teaching (5 min)

-Ending Prayer (1 min)

BIBLE TEACHING

We will be spending some weeks in the letter from James. You might want to print out the first chapter of James from one of the many Bible websites. Double or triple space the text to give yourself space for taking notes and keep a copy in your ring binder together with your other KF materials.

Let's look at **James 1:2**.

The NASB translation reads: "Consider it all joy, my brethren, when you encounter various trials." Last week, we learned that the word *guide* is an alternative translation for the word *consider*. We can *guide* ourselves into all joy in any situation. Isn't that amazing? However, you might wonder where this joy is that we are guiding ourselves into. Most of us have no idea where to find joy, but fortunately we do not have to know where we are going before we begin the journey. Like all journeys, we must simply begin. Jesus really is *The Way*, and on this journey toward reclaiming the True Self, we discover more and more about who He is and who we are becoming. This is the source of all joy.

What are these *various* trials that James talks about? We have learned during these last weeks that trials or experiences are opportunities to discover the truth about who we are and where our real strengths and weaknesses lie. In our passage from First John, we learned that these trials are the days of judgment. They show us the truth about our beliefs and our fearful misorientation. Just as a courtroom will explore what is true, so this day of judgment will explore our hearts and reveal the true quality of our faith and love. Though this experience might sound intimidating, John says that we can be bold in this day of judgment. We get to see how much fear we are carrying in our souls. We also get to see how far we have travelled toward our goal of reorienting to God and living in harmony with His Creation. We no longer shrink back through fear of self-hate. All of this knowing leads to our growing, and growing leads to more knowing. Knowing leads to real self-confidence. Just as the lilies grow without fear, so can you.

This is what Nancy wrote about her own journey toward orientation:

One day while driving, I thought about how difficult these new ideas might be for some of you, especially if you have been trained to think in a certain way. Our KF work reminds me of how difficult it must have been for those who listened to Jesus for the first time. Jesus invited them to rethink their whole culture and upbringing. They naturally felt intimidated and resistant. I thought about a time years ago, long before we ever thought of Karis Fellowships, when I was agonizing about where *Neurosis and Human Growth* and the Romans Bible Study would take me. I was afraid of my own journey; I was afraid of going into the not-knowing. I think fear confuses all of us. When we are in fear, we feel abandoned, and in those moments we need to be reminded that Jesus is with us.

A few years ago, while in prayer, the Lord plainly spoke to me. He said, “*You must be willing to go into the not-knowing.*” (Repeat) I really did not know what His words meant at the time, but all the same they encouraged me to let go of needing to know where this journey would take me. Let me point something out. Letting go of anything is a day of judgment—and it is probably one of our more severe trials or experiments. We find out where our treasure is when we cannot let go, and that can be extremely painful. Some of us have a compulsive need to be *right*. I have always felt that I needed to know the *right* theology, the *right* way to do something, what is *right* about myself, about society, about the choices of others, and what is *wrong* about all of those things. I had to know what was right to support my pride and relieve my anxiety. In that year, God encouraged me to give up needing to know what was right. He encouraged me to just keep growing—or, shall I say, to keep going forward on the journey, producing more of the Fruit of the Spirit in my life. I knew in my heart that if I allowed the fear of being wrong to keep me from going forward, I would be obeying my fears. I would be teaching my heart to love fear rather than to love God. What a loss that would have been! If I had followed my fears, I could not now offer my healing gift to my community, nor would we have Karis Fellowships.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Jesus, help me go into the not-knowing with You. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for this time together. Hold us in the power of this new understanding as You guide us to our glory and, also, to the truth. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self, with the Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.